

...And Yet, a Trace of the True Self Exists in the False Self

Jacques Lacan, a psychoanalytical theorist, coined the notion of the “mirror stage” in infant development; this is the pivotal point upon which one’s initial identification with their mirrored image (thereby becoming an object by virtue of perception) provides both an ideal and false sense of self, more idealized (i.e. objectified) than the previous experience of self in one’s own physical form. This self-identification, in which our internal world splits into internal and external, triggers formation of ego; the imagination is where the ego intersects with signifiers and bridges the disconnect between internal and external worlds. Lacan also identified the power of the gaze and insisted that “the sight alone of the whole form of the human body gives the subject an imaginary mastery over his body, one which is premature in relation to a real mastery”¹; this “imaginary mastery” also suggests an implicit vulnerability as one sees the whole of the object – the self – and presumes an understanding of it that is not yet developed. Lacan also considered dreams to be a manifestation of fragmentation of that “whole form”, the origins of that stemming from a sense of internal lack (the gap between ideal and the real).

Christian Metz, drawing from Lacanian psychoanalysis, suggested that, like the mirror, the “imaginary, by definition, combines within it a certain presence and a certain absence.” (Metz, 44). The fusion of presence and absence is equivalent to the filmic mirror: things are falsely presented to us, present in front of us and yet entirely absent at the same time. Regarding the imaginary, Metz suggests that the “in the cinema it is not just the fictional signified” (Metz 44), but rather the imagination signified; the imaginary signifier of cinema springs forth from a

¹ Lacan, Jacques and John Forrester (Translator). *Seminar I*. 1953-54.

tangible idealization of self that arrives when one identifies with the camera itself. Mirror theory as film theory is not about identify with the characters necessarily as much as identifying with the camera, ultimately identifying with oneself in a mere act of perception; like the development of apperception in infancy, the “mirror” onscreen transports the viewer to a fantasy of perception that transcends the limits of the body, much like a mirror transports one away from the physical form and into the axes of imagination and idealization of self. Inherent in this mirroring is the notion of projection; in the most obvious sense, film is an exercise in projection, literally, as a necessity for viewing. Unlike the true mirror, however, there is no literal reflection of the viewer; the viewer is presumed to understand the signified without seeing their reflection onscreen. In that way, just as much as a film is viewed, or projected, the viewer is also a projector, imbuing a film with an externalization and tangibility that it would not otherwise have by virtue of merely existing elsewhere. Film also eliminates the overt vulnerability of exposure, allowing a voyeuristic, objectifying gaze on behalf of the spectator, who can see but not be seen. More succinctly, the Lacanian influence on film can be identified along several dimensions: mirroring, projection, dreams, objectification, object mastery, and, most relevant to the viewer-camera relationship, the gaze. Psychoanalytic film theory identifies how these aspects create the relationship between viewer and film and engender the viewer’s response to cinema.

Ingmar Bergman’s *Persona* (1966) is a filmic exercise in psychoanalysis and embraces “absence” in its role as imaginary signifier; it acknowledges itself as projection, with references to a literal film projector (both functioning and breaking down), self-awareness of its constructed nature (edits that defy the invisible editing conventions of Hollywood realism, subliminal images with no bearing on the plot), photographic images, and theater. I. Lloyd Michaels notes that the film’s reflexive commentary on imaginary signifiers “presents us with a unique ‘triple

withdrawal': Metz's distance from the object in the theater together with the delegated image of absent objects, *plus* an image which is frequently withdrawn, destroyed, interrupted, or obscured before it can become signified, before we can 'possess' it." (Michaels 73). *Persona* makes the viewer aware of its self-awareness and vacillates between ambiguity and the promise of object mastery, all while engendering an ambiguous parallel between dream-states and spectatorship.

The two main characters, Alma and Elisabeth, seem to role-play their idealized selves while seeing (falsely) a "self" mirrored back in the other woman; they idealize and objectify themselves and each other, attempting to "master" the object of self by way of mastering the other. There is also a great deal of emphasis on being perceived and perception, much like the projection of film and the projection of the viewer; the vulnerability of being objectified is in conflict with their desire to be seen as their idealized selves, so the "gaze" becomes both necessary and disempowering. To become whole, they must "see" each other, but neither can meet or share the gaze of the other as it would shatter their illusions of self, and this is often represented by their proximity to each other in frame but positioning that places one in front of or behind the other, one always looking at the other but neither really looking at each other for any significant period of time; the viewer is also invited to meet the gaze of these women, but can never fully do so, due to high contrast shadows, hazy curtains, and Elisabeth's total refusal to speak. As Michaels noted about the "triple withdrawal", there is a distance, an absence, and an obscuring that denies possession or real mastery of an object.

One sequence that quite successfully condenses elements of mirror theory and psychoanalysis is the scene between Alma and Elisabeth near the end of the film² in which Alma

² [1:06:27 – 1:15:07] Bergman, Ingmar, et al. *Persona*. DVD special ed., The Criterion Collection, 2014.

describes Elisabeth's relationship with her son while the camera focuses exclusively on Elisabeth then repeats the same monologue immediately afterward while the camera is focused on her own face. The full sequence ends with a superimposition of both women's faces, making them almost indistinguishable from one another. There is a photo of Elisabeth's son on the table, calling back to an earlier scene in which Elisabeth rips the photo; here, the photo's absence is important, as Michaels notes "...this same photograph will be deliberately concealed – made absent despite its presence in the shot – by Elisabeth's hands..." (Michaels 75). The distance between viewer and object is reinforced by the hidden photograph and the chiaroscuro of low-key lighting, just as the distance between the two women is reinforced by their refusal to meet each other's gazes, literally and metaphorically, despite the intimate framing and closeness by which the viewer can almost "feel" their reflection or gain proximity to some tangible object that is falsely represented onscreen. The sequence also has a dreamlike quality to it, as it defies narrative convention and the realism of an organic conversation between two women, and assumes a construction that draws attention to itself in such a way to make its "reality" ambiguous; it is a monologue repeated twice, circumstances of this monologue are never indicated, the room is neutral and devoid of context, there are a few noticeable edits between shots that suggest a small jump in time or repositioning of the camera, and yet the monologue does not jump or stop its ongoing rhythm. Time and angle of view are irrelevant in dreams and the unconscious, just as they are here. In Lacanian or Freudian terms, this dream-state mirroring of the two women underscores their fragmentation and sense of "lack" between the idealized self and the real self. The repetition of the monologue also seems to embody a rehearsal, inviting scrutiny upon Bibi Andersson and Liv Ullman as much as Alma and Elisabeth, revealing what Robin Wood describes as an "uncertainty as to where 'acting' stops and 'being' begins" (Wood 193) – a

reference to the duality implicit in the mirroring.

More importantly, this sequence exemplifies the process of objectification, reconciliation, or rejection when they look into the mirror at each other as we look upon them as viewer. As Alma describes Elisabeth's fraught and cold relationship with her child and her fears of leaving theater, Elisabeth looks away then back to the camera then away again to something offscreen – she does not want to meet the gaze or the mirror, as Alma refutes her idealized “self” with the truth of Elisabeth's birth story. Alma is the mirror to Elisabeth's ego and Elisabeth's shadow-shrouded gaze at the camera or offscreen implies an absence of truth or objectivity. Elisabeth's emotional state is revealed on her face to some degree, but she does not speak and is partially ensconced in shadows; unambiguous communication is absent (intentionally ironic, given her reasoning for silence), gaze is obscured. When Alma repeats this scene for the viewer, initially she is partially obscured by Elisabeth sitting in the foreground, very near the camera and barely lit. Low-key lighting and claustrophobic framing implicate the duality of presence and absence, the effect of mirroring, upon which the viewer can impose their own imaginary signifiers just as Alma imposes and projects her sense of self onto Elisabeth as she speaks not only to her, but to herself. Ultimately, they see themselves in idealized fragments more than any object or whole, as their egos do not allow for development beyond the mirror stage; Alma's abortion story is shame-filled for her, but here she treats Elisabeth's attempted abortion as a great moral injury (particularly cutting when she says “you wanted a dead baby”) because she cannot see the reflection of herself without injury to her ego. As she continues her monologue, the camera moves closer and closer to her face; her gaze is now direct and intimate with the viewer, suggesting the viewer is interchangeable with Elisabeth – this is abruptly defied by a split screen of Elisabeth's face with Alma's, perhaps suggesting we are as much Elisabeth as Alma is, and as

much Alma as Elisabeth is. That is to say, who is the object? What is real and what is false?

Alma's reading and re-reading of Elisabeth's relationship with her son constitutes a partially obscured mirror upon which we see aspects of Elisabeth's desired reflection, then Alma's; at the end of the sequence, the only real reflection is an amalgam of both women's faces superimposed on one another (and in Bergman's "Images: My Life in Film" he notes that "the half-illuminated images of Liv's and Bibi's faces that we combined into one showed their respective bad sides." [Bergman 61]), and the camera is oriented directly in front of them before fading to white. This may well be the denouement for the entire film, as it is the closest the viewer gets to "meeting" the gaze of either woman, although this gaze is borne of their "worst" side, and it imbues them with a wholeness that makes them almost possessable and yet impossible to possess. Neither is there on the screen in front of us, and yet both of them are, and within the film neither is there wholly in front of each other, and yet both of them are to some degree. *Persona* (and especially this sequence) embraces the aspect of reduplication described by Metz that substantiates the scene as an imaginary signifier: there is distance created by shadow, things that are both absent and present in some way, and Bergman makes it self-reflexive by featuring the "image which is frequently withdrawn, destroyed, interrupted, or obscured before it can become signified, before we can 'possess' it." (Michaels 73). Elisabeth's stunted emotions toward her son and Alma's abject refusal to adopt this objectification of Elisabeth offer no resolution in finding one's identity through reflection. Maybe the viewer is not meant to identify with either of the two women; this sequence makes it abundantly clear that the viewer is meant instead to identify with themselves through whatever imaginary signifiers fill in the gaps or "project" their own meaning onto the constructed projection. However, neither of these women have successfully moved beyond the mirror stage; as each attempts to gaze upon the other, they

cannot reconcile the perception of them as an object with the subjective understanding they have of themselves, just as we – the proverbial viewer – cannot gaze upon ourselves and see the object reflected as “the true self”. *Persona* as a psychoanalytic endeavor intimates to the viewer that we ARE the image, the tangible object....and simultaneously we are a construction of self-projected ideals and imaginary signifiers, never possessable, always ephemeral.



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